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'Prarthona' by Coke Studio Bangla: Caught between insurrection and co-option?

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Coke Studio resurrects marginalized musical traditions, but then appropriates and commodifies them to create an indigenous version of "modernity."

This year's Ramadan eve saw the release of Coke Studio Bangla's second song, "Prarthona" (Prayer). At the same moment, both mainstream and social media were filled with updates, news, and opinions on a Muslim male police constable's harassment of a Hindu female college teacher for wearing a teep on her forehead. Feminists and social justice activists began condemning the event by posting images of themselves wearing teeps and demonstrating on the streets to their Facebook pages. It was also the moment when misogynistic, masochistic comments about the death of a 21-year-old University of Liberal Arts Bangladesh (Ulab) student riding her scootY by a covered van in a road accident took over social media.Many others condemned the victim for

her "infraction," blaming her clothing and her parents' decision to acquire her a scooty. All of these occurrences flooded my Facebook newsfeed with comments and discussions.

Perhaps these juxtapositions—where people either produce or criticize orthodox, fundamentalist narratives and practices that exploit women and other marginalized communities, while celebrating the release of a spiritual and subversive music composition that celebrates an egalitarian divinity—reflect the unique realities of a postcolonial, neoliberal Bangladesh shaped by myriad globalisation forces.

On the one hand, globalization has enabled foreign direct investment (FDI) and invited The Coca-Cola Company to enter a developing beverage sector in Bangladesh valued at Tk 2,500-3,000 crore. Many Bangladeshis are proud that Coke Studio, which has financed music production in Pakistan, India, Brazil, and other nations, has made a grand entrance into their country, opening opportunities to help local performers and promote local musical traditions. Forgotten here is Coca-lengthy Cola's problematic history of racial discrimination litigation against African-American employees and air pollution in the United States, worsening the situation. Groundwater depletion in India, brutal animal experimentation, monopolization of markets in the United States, Europe, and Mexico, and being the world's single greatest plastic polluter, to mention a few. Coca-Cola recently spent USD 74 million in Bhaluka, Mymensingh, promising to expand not only the plant and infrastructure but also its market and portfolio in Bangladesh. Coke Studio Bangla and its latest release, "Prarthona"—a celebration of "the eternity of virtue and how the true magic of devotion can withstand the test of time, connecting generations, "Old and new," as Coke Studio Bangla calls it, are part of Coca-portfolio Cola's development drive in Bangladesh. to attract support, as well as the globalized political consciousness of returned Bangladeshis mostly male) labor migrants—who are aware of global and class inequities, but reject democratic politics in favor of authoritarian Islamic regimes as a means of achieving prosperity as they have seen in the Middle East—have had a large influence on everyday vocabularies, gendered norms and practices, and other expectations in Bangladesh.

Against this backdrop, Coke Studio Bangla's selection of two songs—"Allah Megh De" and "Baba Maulana"—and their release on the eve of Ramadan provide an intriguing opportunity to critically reflect on both the global Coke empire's imperialist-capitalist invasion, as well as Coke Studio Bangla's powerful subversion of the dominant, orthodox Wahhabi-Salafi popular rhetoric in Bangladesh. Both devotional songs were created and composed by people who did not grow up in Muslim families. Girin Chakraborty wrote and composed "Allah Megh De," and was schooled by great musicians Allauddin Khan and Aftabuddin Khan. Abbasuddin Ahmed, a great folk singer, later sang and popularized the tune. Ramesh Chandra Shil, who was born in India, wrote and composed "Baba Maulana."Ramesh Shil, also known as kobiyal Ramesh Shil or Ramesh Maizbhandari. Ramesh Shil grew raised in Chattogram in a Hindu home. His songs addressed anti-colonial and social justice conflicts such as the revolutionary raid on the

Chattogram Armoury, Surya Sen's self-sacrifice, the non-cooperation and Khilafat campaigns, the 1947 Partition, starvation, and the Language Movement. He turned kobi gaan from an entertainment medium into a tool for political and social justice advocacy. He had a lengthy history of organizing with the Communist Party and was a staunch supporter of the Jukta Front in the East Pakistan provincial election in 1954. He was arrested after Pakistan's federal government abolished the Jukta Front administration. He also adhered to the Maizbhandari Sufi tradition.

The fact that the lyrics, as well as the choice of the two songs, are creatively subversive does not change the fact that Coke Studio Bangla is still embedded in the political economy of what some scholars have referred to as "coca-colonisation," which refers to Coca-aggressive Cola's production and marketing strategies that exploit resources and the environment while favoring global and local elites . The "Prarthona" composition by Coke Studio Bangla challenges Wahhabi/Salafi hegemonic narratives of Islam and promotes for an indigenous, mystical, egalitarian, and subversive new "Muslim" identity. accomplishes so, however, by taking indigenous, folk, and Sufi music traditions that were historically performed in dargahs and setting them in an experimental studio.

It was traditionally held in dargahs, and relocating it to an experimental studio. Mizan Rahman, who was never engaged with the Maizbhandari lineage, becomes the main vocalist for "Baba Maulana," and Momtaz Begum's normal flamboyant self and non-elite rawness is changed into a sanitised and derivative "mellow, controlled vocalisation." Coke Studio resurrects minoritised musical traditions, but then appropriates and commodifies them to create an indigenous version of "modernity."

Source : Coke studio bangla authorities and press realese .